Technique, Method & Methodology

Research methods in anthropology: (b) distinction between technique, method and methodology — and the approaches to inquiry

4 PYQs 2006 · 2007 · 2019 · 2026
+ the exact phrase 1986–93 · 2026 mixed methods (20M) · 2025 science vs humanities (20M) adjacent · Mains Value **High**

THE ANSWER SPINE ① Three levels → ② Two methodologies → ③ The observer → ④ Experience → ⑤ Integration

① THE DISTINCTION

1987 · 1990 · 1993 opens every answer

HOOK *Cooking: technique = how you chop; method = the recipe; methodology = your theory of good food and how you'd know it is good.*

Level	Answers	Examples
Technique — a specific tool	with what?	schedule, questionnaire, genealogy chart, map, pile sort
Method — a strategy	how?	participant observation, case study, genealogical, comparative, survey
Methodology — logic of inquiry	why, and how do we know?	positivism, interpretivism, phenomenology, pragmatism

Above: **paradigm** (Kuhn 1962) · **ontology** (what reality is) · **epistemology** (how it is known). Below: **research design**. Hierarchical, **not one-to-one** — one questionnaire can serve two methodologies. **Pelto & Pelto 1970**; Bernard 1988.

Pairs: inductive / deductive · qualitative / quantitative · emic / etic (Pike 1954) · idiographic / nomothetic (Windelband 1894) · holistic / analytic.

② POSITIVIST VS NON-POSITIVIST

2007 · 2025 (20M)

HOOK *Evans-Pritchard ran his household by the Azande poison oracle — and found it as good a way as any of managing his affairs. Understanding from within.*

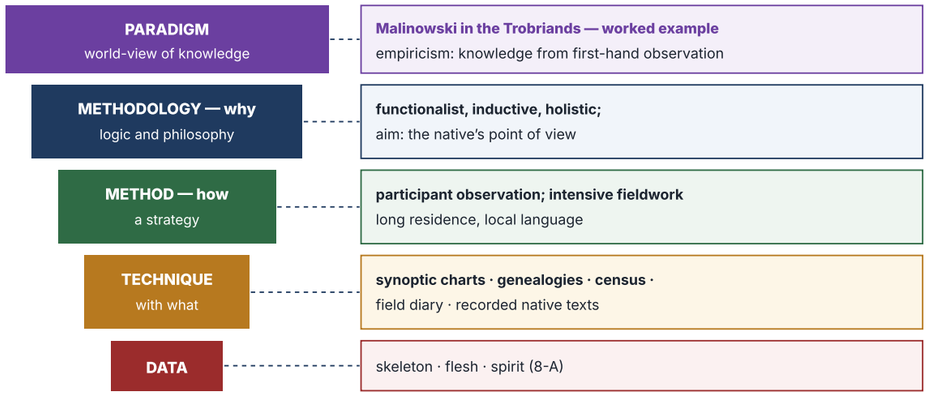
Basis	Positivist — explain	Interpretive — understand
Reality	objective	constructed, meaningful
Aim	causal laws	meaning
Logic	deductive	inductive
Data	measured	words, symbols, acts
Observer	neutral	positioned, reflexive
Names	Comte · Durkheim 1895 · Radcliffe-Brown · Murdock HRAF 1937 · Harris	Weber (Verstehen) · Boas · Evans-Pritchard 1950 · Geertz 1973

Basis	Qualitative	Quantitative
Aim	meaning, process	measurement, cause
Sample	small, purposive	large, random
Tools	observation, life history	survey, census, anthropometry

Gives / costs: rigour, comparison vs lost context · meaning, actor's view vs weak generalisation. **Verdict:** complementary — anthropology **bridges science and the humanities**.

★ HERO — THREE LEVELS OF ONE RESEARCH ACT

draw for any "distinguish" stem



technique: with what? · method: how? · methodology: why, and how do we know?

③ SUBJECTIVITY — THE OBSERVER PROBLEM

2006

HOOK *Tepoztlán: Redfield (1926) saw harmony, Lewis (1943) saw conflict. Samoa: Mead (1928) saw ease, Freeman (1983) said she was hoaxed. Same places, different methodologies.*

Where it enters: choice of problem and site · the researcher's gender, nation, caste, class, theory · which informants · what is noticed · interpretation · writing. **Observer effect:** people act for the visitor.

Remedies: reflexivity · long residence · many informants · **triangulation** (Denzin 1970: data, investigator, theory, method) · team and repeat studies · member checking · transparent notes. **As resource:** experiential turn (Rosaldo 1989). **Intersubjectivity** (Schutz).

Basis	Method	Methodology
Nature	practical procedure	philosophical justification
Example	participant observation	interpretivism that values it

✎ EXAM OPENERS — HOOKS YOU CAN WRITE

first two lines

- **Distinction:** "Redfield found Tepoztlán harmonious, Lewis found it in conflict — the difference lay in methodology, not the village."
- **Positivism:** "Evans-Pritchard ran his house by the poison oracle: anthropology must understand before it explains."
- **Mixed methods:** "People of India profiled 4,635 communities with one schedule and one ethnography each."

④ PHENOMENOLOGY AS METHOD

2019 · 15M

HOOK *Paul Stoller's Songhay sorcerer-teacher told him to stop watching and learn with his body — hence The Taste of Ethnographic Things (1989).*

Philosophy: Husserl — "back to the things themselves", **epoché** (bracketing), **lifeworld** · Heidegger 1927 being-in-the-world · Schutz 1932 intersubjectivity · **Merleau-Ponty 1945** the lived body.

Anthropology: Jackson, *Paths Toward a Clearing* 1989 (Kuranko) · **Csordas 1990** embodiment as paradigm (→ 2025 note) · Stoller 1987/1989 · Kleinman, *Illness Narratives* 1988 · Bourdieu's habitus 1977 · Gopal Guru, *Humiliation* 2009.

Method: bracket categories · participant **experience** · open interviews, narratives · senses, emotion, body, time, space. **Critique: subjectivism · weak generalisation · neglects structure and power · can experience be shared?**

⑤ MIXED METHODS

2026 · 20M

HOOK *People of India (AnSI, K. S. Singh, 1985–92): 4,635 communities, one common schedule and one ethnographic profile each.*

Definition: combine and **integrate** qualitative and quantitative data and methods (Creswell & Plano Clark 2007; Tashakkori & Teddlie 1998). **Basis:** pragmatism.

- **Convergent** — quan + qual together → merge
- **Explanatory** — quan first → qual explains (census drop-out → why)
- **Exploratory** — qual first → quan scales (free-lists → survey)
- **Embedded** — one strand inside the other

Examples: Lewis's Tepoztlán (census, budgets, Rorschach + fieldwork) · Rivers' genealogies · nutrition anthropology (2025) · NFHS + fieldwork · PRA evaluations.

Counter-case — the limits: paradigm clash · cost, time, skills · shallow integration (two studies side by side) · qual reduced to illustration.

Traps: method ≠ methodology · participant observation is a method, the diary a technique · mixing ≠ integrating.

THE VERDICT TO WRITE Technique answers **"with what?"**, method **"how?"**, methodology **"why, and how do we know?"** — and a good study is consistent across all three. Positivist and interpretive methodologies are complementary, not rival: anthropology **explains and understands**. Subjectivity cannot be removed, only acknowledged and checked; phenomenology turns experience into evidence; and **mixed methods**, genuinely integrated, is the practical bridge between science and the humanities.